

for *India Junction*, these were “liminal spaces”, which symbolized change, “disrupted social order”, and a place where “one might go to die” or even “come back to life”. There was no doubt, “you only had to catch sight of a train passing and everyone knew that something drastic had happened”.

Sites of adventure and change

The first few Indian movies converted the thrill and speed of a train shooting down its tracks into a live site of action and adventure. *Miss Frontier Mail* (1936), *Deccan Queen* (1936), *Toofan Mail* (1934), *11 O’Clock* (1948), *Punjab Mail* (1939) — it was as if the sense of adventure of being on a train journey, its speeding whirl, were reified on screen. The visual trope of the train as a site of a waylaid robbery became common through the 1970s and 1980s. Perhaps the most iconic was Ramesh Sippy’s *Sholay* (1975), which introduced the protagonists, Jai and Veeru, as they fought horsebound dacoits on a moving freight train. Climactic chase sequences and impending disasters were a popular theme, such as *The Burning Train* (1980). It told the story of a newly introduced Super Express being threatened by the possibility of a bomb exploding, the imagery of crash and rescue at play.

In other films, the railways served as the archetype of change and modernity, such as in Satyajit Ray’s *Pather Panchali* (1955), as little Apu and Durga ran through tall, swaying, white *kashphool* (type of grass) just in time to catch sight of a steam train hurtling by. In Mani Ratnam’s *Guru* (2007), the train marked the separation from home and setting out to earn one’s fortunes, while the train in Anil Sharma’s *Gadar: Ek Prem Katha* (2001) drove home the pain and violence of Partition.